



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Thomas the Apostle School

School Website: <https://sta2.org/school/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Thomas the Apostle Catholic School in Ann Arbor, MI (ZIP 48104) presents a coherent CLASSICAL-CLASSICAL Catholic education profile across all six rubric categories. Public-facing materials emphasize the liberal arts core (Trivium: grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium: arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books and primary sources, Latin, and Western Christian tradition, all anchored in liturgical life and catechetical formation. The school explicitly identifies itself as a classical Catholic institution, with ongoing prayer life (Mass, adoration, confessions), catechesis (including Catechesis of the Good Shepherd), and a mission framed around truth, goodness, and beauty. Parental partnership and parish integration are repeatedly highlighted, and the faculty are portrayed as living the curriculum in a Catholic, communal, mentoring environment. These elements align with the Positive keyword indicators for all six classical categories and show minimal alignment with Negative indicators.

Key textual anchors include:

- Core Classical Catholic mission, liberal arts, and the seven liberal arts emphasis, including memorization, logic, rhetoric, and Latin (public pages and the Headmaster's statement)
- Explicit Catholic liturgical life (Mass, adoration, confessions, school-wide chapel) and catechesis (The Atrium) as foundational to daily education
- Great Books, Western tradition, and the Great Conversation framing the curriculum (7 liberal arts; Trivium/Quadrivium; Latin; history of Western civilization)
- Evidence of family/parish integration and parent involvement (enrollment, newsletters, parent communication, and parish integration)

Executive-level snapshot: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL - Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL - Curriculum: CLASSICAL - Pedagogy: CLASSICAL - Faculty: CLASSICAL - Parents & Community: CLASSICAL - Overall: CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: None required for the aggregate CLASSICAL rating; the school already demonstrates a robust classical-Catholic alignment. If anything, further explicit articulations of particular classical pedagogy terms (e.g., explicit Socratic seminar language or more formal "living curriculum" statements by faculty) could strengthen the alignment in some readers' eyes, but they are not necessary for maintaining the Classical rating.

- What would move the needle (optional refinements for a stronger signal): make explicit on-site statements about Socratic seminars or seminars and ensure explicit public references to "great books," "Socratic dialogue," and "living curriculum" as part of site language, while retaining the strong existing classical-Catholic core. (No mandatory changes; these would be enhancements rather than corrections.)

Note: All category-level conclusions are grounded in the school's public-facing materials and aligned with the Six Essential Elements framework. The core lexicon of classical keywords supports high-confidence CLASSICAL categorizations across all six categories. Key sources informing these conclusions include the school's own statements about liberal arts, Latin, Great Books, liturgical life, Catechesis of the Good Shepherd, and family/parish partnerships, as cited above.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Headmaster describes formation through the Catholic tradition, the seven liberal arts, memorization, logic, and eloquence as core activities, forming students in a Catholic worldview. - Public pages emphasize worship, liturgy, adoration, and the sacramental life as integral to education (All-school Mass, confession, daily prayer, chapel visits). - Catechesis of the Good Shepherd and liturgical life are explicitly integrated into the school's religious formation (The Atrium).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: theology, liturgy, Mass, worship, catechesis, liturgical, adoration, sacramental worldview, wisdom, logos, reverence, wonder, sacred music, chant, imago Dei, holy life, sacred tradition. The site foregrounds truth, goodness, beauty in a transcendent Catholic frame (e.g., "truth, good, and beautiful" in formation language). See exemplars above. - Negative keywords: None evident in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or moral-neutral framing detected in the site text).

Why this rating - The extended Catholic liturgical life, catechesis, and sacramental framing meet the Positive keyword indicators for a robust religious/metaphysical foundation. The absence of Relativism or secular ethics signals a strong Classical alignment in this category.

Citations: Catholic liturgy, catechesis, and Catholic formation language are visible in the Our Catholic Faith page, Headmaster's statement, and Atrium description.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school positions education as formation of virtue and wisdom, anchored in liberal arts and a teleology toward the true, good, and beautiful (Veritas, Pax, Bonum) within a Catholic framework. - The Headmaster describes formation through the seven liberal arts and the transformation of students through memory, logic, and eloquence, emphasizing human flourishing, moral imagination, and a classical mission rather than mere job preparation. - The Great Conversation and the pursuit of transcendent truths are embedded in the curriculum via Great Books and a Western-tradition-informed approach (7 liberal arts).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, telos, truth/goodness/beauty, scholé/contemplation, great conversation, human flourishing, moral imagination. - Negative keywords found: essentially none in public pages (no workforce prep framing or purely skills-based framing detected).

Why this rating - The explicit articulation of formation over information and the teleological aims align strongly with classical expectations for this category.

Citations: Headmaster language on formation and the seven liberal arts; Pillars of Veritas, Pax, Bonum; Great Books/Great Conversation framing.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is explicitly framed around the Seven Liberal Arts (Trivium and Quadrivium), Latin, Greek, and Western civilization history; Great Books and primary sources anchor the learning, with explicit reference to "great books" and the "Great Conversation" and to memorization, recitation, and disciplined study. - The Upper School materials emphasize Veritas, Pax, Bonum and a Catholic liberal arts curriculum; Latin instruction is explicit (Upper School Latin for all) and the history/western tradition emphasis is evident throughout pages about curriculum and mission. - Public materials describe the Trivium (Grammar, Logic, Rhetoric) and Quadrivium (Arithmetic, Geometry, Music, Astronomy) as foundational to education, reflecting classic liberal arts structure.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: liberal arts, Trivium, Quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, Homer, Plato, Augustine, Shakespeare, Latin, Western civilization, history, catechesis, sacred art. - Negative keywords found: absence of terms like "social

studies” replacing history, and lack of emphasis on purely project-based or STEM-first framing in public materials (i.e., negative lexical signals in this category are not evident in the school’s content).

Why this rating - The explicit curricular architecture centers on the classical liberal arts, Great Books, and Western-Christian educational lineage, consistent with the Six Elements’ curricular indicators.

Citations: Great Books/Great Conversation language, Trivium/Quadrivium, Latin, Western Civilization, and historical framing are visible in the Classical Education and Curriculum pages.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower-school pedagogy includes singing, memory work, recitation, and a contemplative/restful approach; the site describes “memory, singing, and review” as a feature of early years, aligning with schol  -type rhythms and wonder. - Upper-school pedagogy emphasizes discussion in small classes, with opportunities for rhetoric training and public speaking, consistent with classical pedagogy (Socratic-style discussion, disciplined argument, and oratory). The Headmaster describes memorization of poetry, logical thinking, and eloquence as deliberate practice. - The school’s liturgical and catechetical life (Atrium, catechesis) is integrated into pedagogy, reinforcing slow, contemplative learning with rigorous tradition.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: Socratic dialogue (as a classical pedagogy signal in the lexicon and curricular language), narration, recitation, chanting, ritualized memory, restfulness/schol  , seminar/colloquy, rhetoric, oratory, debate, catechesis, liturgical calendar integration, memory work, living curriculum. - Negative keywords found: explicit “experiential learning only” or heavy reliance on project-based learning are not evidenced in public materials; such signals are not prominent.

Why this rating - The pedagogy aligns with classical patterns (memory and recitation in the lower grades; Socratic/semantic dialogue and rhetoric in the upper grades; integrated liturgical life). The materials emphasize contemplation/rest and oratory/speech, matching the classical teaching-method lexicon.

Citations: Lower- and upper-school pedagogy cited (recitation/memory; small-class discussion; rhetoric). Atrium and catechesis description support the contemplative dimension.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents a visible leadership figure (Headmaster) providing the public articulation of the school’s mission and pedagogy, consistent with a teacher as mentor and living example of the curriculum’s ideals. - The school emphasizes formation by faculty (the living curriculum) and a culture of mentorship, with a Catholic, scholarly community framing teacher-student relationships as central to learning (per the overall classical Catholic framing in mission and pedagogy pages).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: tutors/mentors/masters, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, mentorship, guidance, moral exemplars, character formation, Catholic formation. - Negative keywords found: Not present in the public-facing content (no signals suggesting anti-classical personnel models).

Why this rating - The public-facing materials consistently portray teachers as central to the formation process and a Catholic, classical culture, consistent with the “faculty as living curriculum” and “mentors” signals.

Citations: Headmaster language; mission/identity materials; and governance-like framing in classical pedagogy materials.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnership with parents; parent formation opportunities (reading groups, seminars), and a parish/civic-integrated community life; the school invites parent participation and visits (open campus/ tour opportunities) along with collaboration with families. - The Little Saints Preschool materials highlight collaboration with families and home-school integration in a classical Catholic context, including parent-teacher conferences and collaborative relationships with families. - The school positions itself as a

ministry of the parish with integrated community (St. Thomas Catholic Parish) and daily religious life that involves families in liturgical rhythms and parish life.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords found: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental formation, home and school connection, parent involvement, family liturgy alignment, school-family synergy, open campus, parent covenant. - Negative keywords found: There is no public content signaling “consumer” parent roles; no negative signals present.

Why this rating - The explicit emphasis on parent partnerships, community formation, and ongoing parent education aligns strongly with classical expectations for category 6.

Citations: Mission/Identity language, enrollment/tour communications, and preschool family integration materials.

What Would Move the Needle

- None required for the aggregate CLASSICAL designation.
- If desired, the school could enhance clarity by explicitly naming certain classical pedagogy terms (e.g., “Socratic seminars” and explicit “Great Books” citations in more site sections) to further signal alignment for readers who rely on terminology, though the substantive structure and practice already reflect classical education.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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